



Department
for Work &
Pensions

Services
Week

2026

Stéphanie Krus

Senior Service Designer
Department for Work and Pensions

The logo for Services Week 2026 is located in the top left corner. It features the words "Services Week" in a bold, black, sans-serif font, with "2026" in a larger, outlined, sans-serif font below it. The text is set against a background of overlapping yellow and pink geometric shapes.

**Services
Week
2026**

How a service designer can contribute to accessibility

“Personalised public services”

An invite to explore how services can be designed around the individual needs, circumstances and experiences of the people who use them...

+ people who are delivering them

+ those involved in designing them



This year's theme is “Personalised public services” – an invite to explore how services can be designed around the individual needs, circumstances and experiences of the people who use them. But I'm a service designer so I'm going to extend the theme and also look at the needs of the people who are delivering the service and those involved in designing them

What I will take you through

- how we created the guidance
- making your service accessible
- design communication
- designing together
- key takeaways and resources



I will use the guidance for the service designer role from the DWP accessibility manual as a thread to take you through

About me

- my pronouns are she/her
- have been a software developer
- a UX designer and researcher
- now a service designer
- very keen on accessibility and inclusion



my pronouns are she/her,

I'm French in case you are still wondering about my accent.

I started working in government in 2016 as a software developer for the Ministry of Justice

I became a UX designer and researcher for a council in 2018,
then transitioned again to service design in 2019

and now working for DWP since 2023, first as a contractor and now as a permanent.
During all that time, I've always been very keen on accessibility and inclusion

Each role in a multi-disciplinary team has a part to play to avoid making a service inaccessible



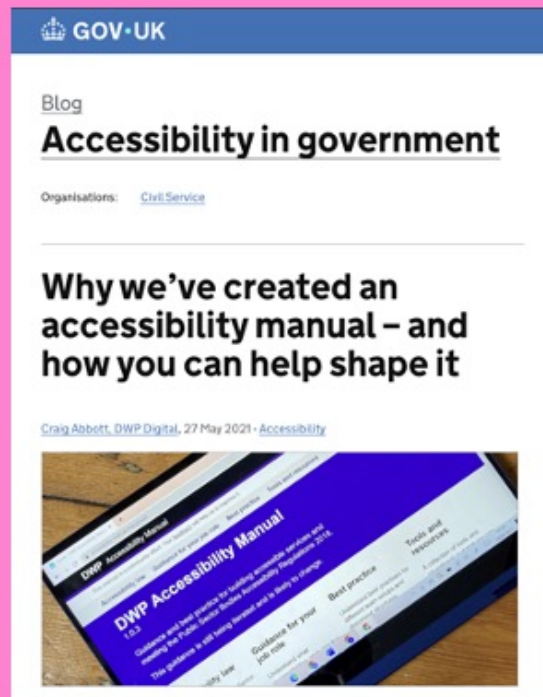
Because of my experience going from one role to another, I'm very aware that each role in a multi-disciplinary team has a different part to play to avoid making a service inaccessible.

It works better if everyone knows their part, so that the accessibility of a service do not rely on one single very keen individual reminding everyone what they should be doing.

This is why guidance per role feels really important to me.

DWP Accessibility manual

How we created the guidance for the service designer role



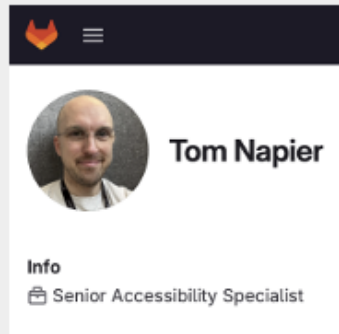
When the manual was first created in 2021, it was unique. Nothing like that existed in government even though it was badly needed.

Now there is also the DfE accessibility and inclusion manual but in terms of guidance per role, they do not have much yet.

The manual was very useful and very well received at the time. My favourite part was the guidance per role, so I started pointing people to it during my presentations, at work, or outside work,

There was a guidance for pretty much all the role we have in a multidisciplinary team in government, but not for the service designer role.

Joining DWP in 2023



2 reasons:

- not enough time
- unsure what a service designer does

When I joined DWP in 2023 as a contractor, I talked to Tom Napier, he is a senior accessibility specialist.

I contacted him about the project I was on, but in the conversation, I mentioned the manual and it turned out he was the one in charge of maintaining it, I told him how I kept directing people to the manual even before I joined DWP, but that the service designer role was missing in it.

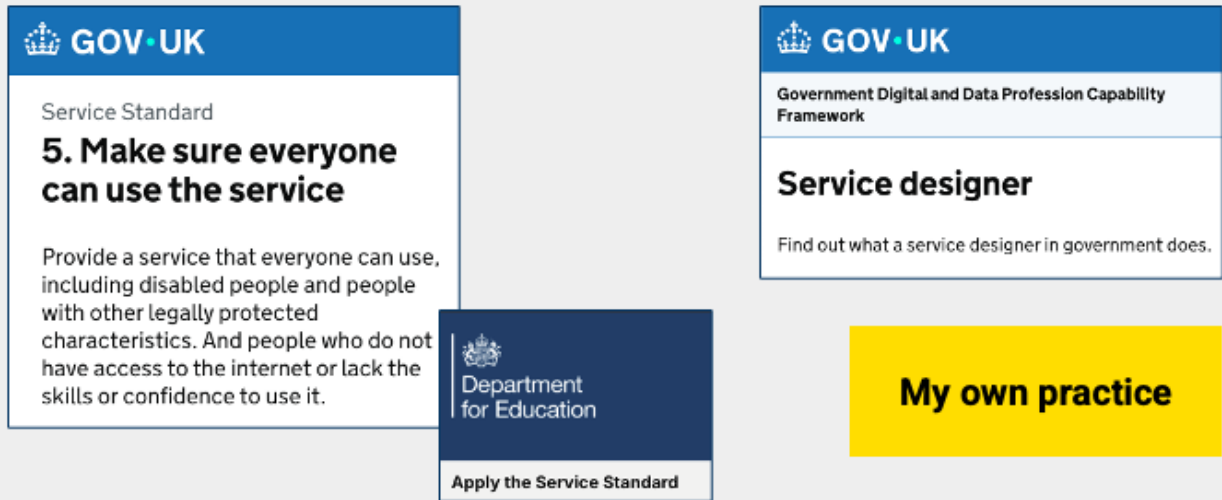
There were 2 reasons, not enough time at that point, but also he was unsure about what a service designer does and how this contributes to accessibility.

Which is was not surprising to me, because every time I join a project team, no one seems to be too sure about what a service designer do apart from creating maps maybe?

I keep having to explain what I do.

But Tom was happy to work on a guidance with me.

The service designer role



I was very happy about this and started looking at:

- [point 5 of the service standard](#) which describes what is needed to make sure everyone can use the service, which includes disabled people.
- I also looked at the [guidance of the Department for Education's guidance on how to apply the service standard for point 5](#) as they go in a bit more details
- I've checked the description of the service designer within the [Government Digital and Data Profession Capability Framework](#)
- and finally I've added elements from my own practice as a service designer

That's all the material I had to start working on a guidance.

Involving the Service Design Community



That was my initial plan, but I wanted to involve the wider service design community in DWP too, because I'm just one service designer, and there are different ways to practice service design.

So we work on it in 3 phases:

one online service design community session where we had invited Tom so he could hear first hand what we felt our role was regarding accessibility.

Tom worked on a draft guidance based on this.

And then during an in person community day in March, we worked in groups to refine the guidance and it got much better as a result.

I'm really glad I involved the community because it took the guidance much further and made it much better than whatever I could have done working by myself with Tom.

Soon after, in April 2025, the guidance was published.

What the guidance covers

- WCAG Conformance
- Non-digital accessibility
- Design communication
- Design together
- When you can't make a part of your service accessible



DWP Accessibility Manual

This manual is a community effort. [Email your feedback](#) to help us to improve it.

[Accessibility law](#) [Guidance for your job role](#) [Best practice](#)

Service Designer

As a Service Designer, you'll have an overview of an entire end-to-end service, back to front. You'll design journeys across both digital and offline channels. That means you'll be able to consider how accessibility is impacted across the whole service.

You should ensure your designs meet accessibility standards. You should familiarise yourself with:

- the [Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\)](#)
- the [Cognitive accessibility guidelines \(COGA\)](#)

Both are published by the [World Wide Web Consortium \(W3C\)](#).

You should also have an understanding of the different ways that users access content and be able to explain ways to meet those requirements.

In Government, services we build must be accessible to everyone who needs them. This includes public servants too. As a Service Designer, you will be designing a service that may be used by external people or staff, or both.

Your overview of the end-to-end service may give you an insight into inclusivity for both external and internal users. Others on your team might not have this insight, so you should be an advocate in your team for all your users.

You can read more about the role of Service Designer on the [Government Digital and Data Profession Capability Framework](#).

Since April 2025, the service designer role has its guidance page.

I'm going to tell you a bit more about the guidance itself now that you now how it came to be created.

It covers the bullet points on the slides, and I'm going to go in a bit more details about each of them during the rest of the talk.

[Guidance for the service designer role](#)

What's different in this role?

- “Your overview of the end-to-end service may give you an insight into inclusivity for both external and internal users”
- “You’ll design journeys across both digital and offline channels”
- Non digital accessibility → [Accessible events toolkit](#) from [Scope](#)

So first, what's actually different and specific to this role?

Others on your team might not have this insight, so you should be an advocate in your team for all your user, both internal and external.

Parts of your service, as well as some of your design activities, might occur offline. You must consider non digital accessibility too.

The Disability charity [Scope](#) has lots of guidance around accessibility in the built environment. Scope provides guidance for users on how to [check the accessibility of an event or venue](#).

This can be useful to understand what things you should consider when parts of your service require people to attend a place in person.

Scope for Business also have an [accessible events toolkit](#) that you may find useful

When you can't make part of your service accessible

- a service, technically accessible online might not be the best solution
- you can and should ask for help from accessibility specialists

There are 2 meanings to this: you are in a situation where an alternative option is a better than spending a lot of time on making a digital solution more accessible

For example, consider the digital self-check-in at Jobcentres. It might be difficult to change accessibility settings if you need to use a screen reader and cannot hear in the busy environment. Speaking to a person could provide a better experience.

Bringing the community along with me to improve the guidance highlighted that some service designers might not know how to make things accessible by themselves. We are not trained to do this, so if no one in your team can help, you need to work with accessibility specialists (in your department, cross government, but you could also bring in associations

Accessibility



Just in case some of you are not familiar with accessibility, I'm going to give a quick overview.

1 in 4 people are disabled in the UK

vision



hearing



speech



motor



cognitive



It's different for everyone

1 in 4 people are disabled in the UK

A disability can affect your vision, your hearing or your speech.

It can be a physical disability or a cognitive disability, this means it affects your memory, or how you process things, communicate and think.

It can also be a mix of more than one disability.

In fact, it's quite frequent that people have more than one disability and they are not always visible to others.

It's different for everyone

[Source for 1 in 4 - disability prevalence by age group](#)

Defining accessibility

“Accessibility means that people can do what they need to do in a similar amount of time and effort as someone that does not have a disability.

It means that people are empowered and can be independent.”

Source: [GOV.UK Blog post](#)

Web Content Accessibility Guidelines

→ Standard you need to comply with for digital accessibility

Currently, version 2.2

[Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\)](#)

Published by the [World Wide Web Consortium \(W3C\)](#)

We have a link to this in the guidance, but it's not always easy to engage with - The DWP accessibility manual have some more engaging guidance around this

Cognitive Accessibility Guidelines (COGA)

→ set of guidelines for inclusive design

Also published by the W3C.

[Nice COGA version by the Department for Education](#)

a set of guidelines for inclusive design.
covers a lot of issues around neurodiversity
and was included in the guidance for our role as it's very useful
The Department for Education has a really engaging version of COGA [link on the slide]

Neurodiversity

- Dyslexia
- Autism
- ADHD (= Attention Deficit and Hyperactivity Disorder)
- Dyspraxia
- Dyscalculia
- OCD (Obsessive Compulsive Disorder)
- Tourette's syndrome and more

Neurodiversity is an umbrella term which cover conditions like Dyslexia, Autism, ADHD and other 'dys' like dyspraxia, or dyscalculia, OCD, Tourette's syndrome and more. There is a lot of overlap between these conditions.

How neurodiversity affects people

- think, process information and language
- interact socially and communicate with others
- perceive space and time

1 in 7 people are neurodivergent

This is about 15 to 20% of the general population
But it's often underestimated and under-declared.

It's much higher for people working in Tech.
→ above 20% and **probably up to 50% in tech** and the creative industry

1 in 7 people are neurodivergent in the UK - that's about 15 to 20 % of the general population.

It's often underestimated and under declared because even though things are improving, it's still often perceived negatively, so people are wary of disclosing.

Many people don't have a diagnosis, it takes a long time to get one, and some people are not even aware that they are neurodivergent, especially women, as the description of these conditions are still full of stereotypes and more representative of young boys than girls and even less of adult women who often have learned to cope and mask.

It looks like these numbers are much higher for people working in tech.

It's very hard to have reliable numbers, I've got 3 sources which I added to the notes of the slide.

And some of the numbers are showing that it's above 20% in tech and the creative industry and probably up to 50% in some cases.

So if you consider the people in your team, it's very likely that quite a few are neurodivergent.

I'll come back to this at the end when talking about designing with your team and communicating your design.

[Major new report from the Tech Talent Charter reveals tech employers massively underestimate neurodivergence](#) - We are Tech women (Feb 2024)

[What it's like being neurodivergent in the creative industries](#) - Creative review (Avril 2024)

[Written evidence given to a UK Parliament committee](#) (PDF)

Designing for everyone



General recommendations

1 in 4 people
are disabled

- think of accessibility right from the start
- involve disabled people at every stage of your research
- don't forget internal users
- everyone in your team needs to be involved
- ask for feedback (accessible and not only online)

Some general recommendations

You need to think about accessibility right from the start, not at the very end as it will influence your decisions all along

1 in 4 people are disabled in the UK, so ideally, you should have a similar proportion of disabled people taking part in your research.

Don't forget internal users, they could also have accessibility issues while delivering the service, so do think about them too.

Make sure everyone in your team understand how to avoid making things inaccessible without meaning to.

Everyone has a role to play.

Make it easy for people to tell you when something is not right.

Even if you have done a really good work, you are likely to overlook some issues, so this feedback is crucial to keep improving your service.

If your feedback mechanism is only online and not accessible, you are going to miss out on a lot of inclusion issues...

So make sure the way you request feedback is accessible and not only online.

Numbers

Low numeracy affects half the working-age adults in the UK

[Accessible numbers project](#)

by Laura Parker

Designing for users with dyscalculia or low numeracy



Do...

round numbers to the nearest whole number



leave space around numbers



fill in the information you already have



use sentences to add context about numbers

1 in 20
people have
dyscalculia

let people include spaces when entering numbers

12 34 56

user research with people who struggle with numbers



Do not...

use decimals unless it's money



overwhelm people with too much content



expect users to repeat or remember numbers



use tables and grids without explaining what the numbers mean

2231
2578
11

rush users to enter a number accurately



force people to enter a number or do a sum to verify themselves



Don't forget about users with dyscalculia and low numeracy.

Low numeracy affects half the working-age adults in the UK - this is a lot of people among your users but it could also be your colleagues, in your team or among people delivering the service.

To learn more about this, you can check the [Accessible numbers project](#) by Laura Parker, there is advice and podcast episodes to understand how to do better. I really recommend it.

A while ago now, Laura worked with Rachel Malic and Jane McFadyen to create a new do and don't poster for designing for people with dyscalculia or low numeracy: [link to a blogpost explaining how they made this poster.](#)

End-to-End, Back to front

- Integration with other services
- Asking Questions
- Consistency
- Service features guidance in the manual
 - Redundant entry
 - Accessible authentication success criteria

In the guidance for a service designer, we have mentioned WCAG which is very wide, but for this role, we wanted to focus on a few points, which relates to the fact that we are the one person looking at the end-to-end and back-to-front service

Integration with other services

You should consider the accessibility of any other services you want to integrate with before deciding to include them in your design. These other services may have an impact on the accessibility of your design. For example, your service may pass the user to an authentication service before returning them to the main journey.

Asking Questions

Many services ask questions for users to answer. You should ensure that you don't ask the user the same thing over and over.

This can be harder than it sounds. Repeated questions can be difficult to avoid when designing a complex service with many integrations.

Consistency

The way you navigate the service and ask for help should be consistent across integrations if possible. As well as testing features of the service, you should be testing whole journeys.

The DWP Accessibility manual has a [Service features guidance](#) part.

Service Designers should pay particular attention to it.

These pages provide more detailed information on the WCAG success criteria to consider.

In particular: Redundant Entry and Accessible Authentication success criteria.

Design communication



Some basic steps

- Use legible fonts, and structure your text with the right headings
- check colour contrast especially for your text
- do not rely on colour alone to convey meaning
- use plain language and explain acronyms
- be careful with numbers
- use accessibility checkers for your slides
- send your presentation ahead of the meeting when possible

This is really for everyone in the team really not just service designers

Maps

- colour contrast are still important, and not just for the text
- legible font is still important, but more flexibility on the size
- beware: people will look for meaning in colours and alignment
- not too much info, not too many colours and shapes
- who is your audience? what's your intent?
- create alternative formats

This one is more specific to service designer, because people do not always know what a service designer does, but we are usually known as the person 'who does the maps'.

And these can be powerful tools to communicate your design.

Example:

Mapping an ecosystem

Ecosystem of the service v1.3



On this slide, I have a colourful ecosystem map.

At the top, I usually put a version number for that map, and in the top right corner, I usually explain what an ecosystem is and what we will use this for.

I also add the date when it was last updated.

The map itself show the usual elements I have in an ecosystem:

The primary group of users, and other groups potential support around the group, and charities and other 3rd parties. I will have some arrows to show the relationships between these groups

I often have a part showing the teams, the systems and actors who are delivering the service internally, and relations they might have with other government departments.

Here I've put the policy team and relation to piece of legislation the service needs to comply with

And finally in this example, I've put a local authority part and within it departments with potential actors and what they do.

Once the mapping is in a good place, and I want to start sharing wider, I create an alternative format as a slide deck, and provide the same level of information but easier to use and engage for people who do not function visually or feel it's too much to take in one go.

Example: Turning the ecosystem visual into a deck (1)

Name of the service or project

Ecosystem of the service v1.3

Last updated 03/09/2025

What is an ecosystem map

Explanation of the purpose of this type of map

Setting expectations

How to read this map

If people still want to understand and use the visual

Ecosystem of the service v1.3



Description of the map

I have an 'educational slide' and provide a link to a PDF version of the visual as some people might still be interested in seeing it, and then I provide a written description of the visual.

[explain what an ecosystem is]

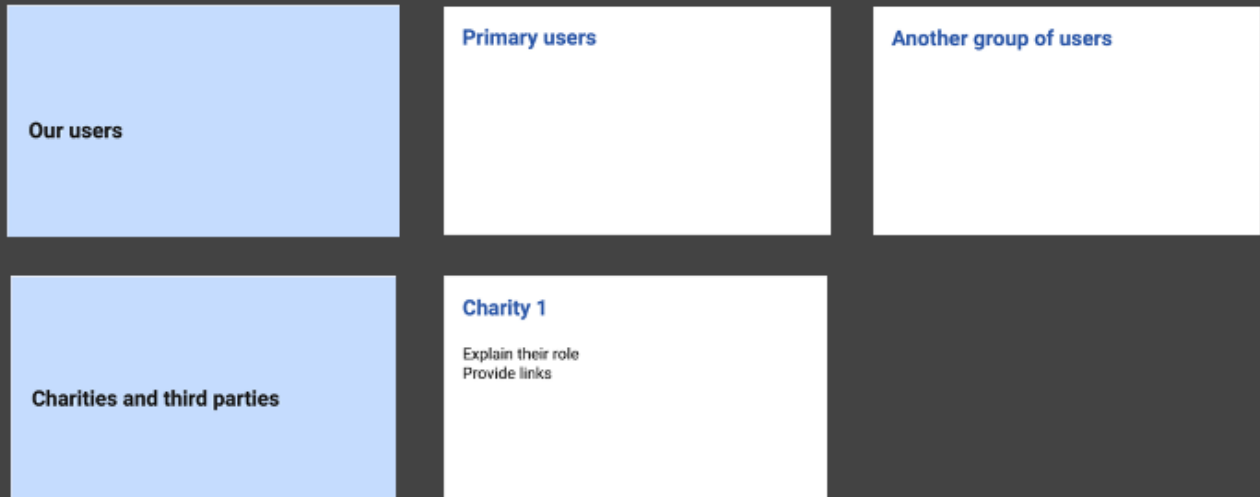
"This is mapping actors like people, teams, organisations, but also systems, documents and 3rd parties, or anyone else that might be part of the service or affected by the service and the type of interactions/relationships between them at a high level.

This is a visual, which will help us understand better the different parts of the service and who we need to involve in the design/discussion.

The value is more in doing the map than the resulting map as it will highlight gaps we might have, but the finished map can still be useful for people who want to understand the service.

Once we start discussing future changes to the service, it will help us see who will be affected by our changes"

Example: Turning the ecosystem visual into a deck (2)



I start with the users, and 3rd parties. In a deck I can provide a bit more information and add links. I describe the relationships which are sometimes less obvious in a deck.

It might have a bit of duplication compared to a visual.

Example: Turning the ecosystem visual into a deck (3)

The delivery of the service internally

An area of the department

Description of the team and what they do

Policy - Legal

Description of the teams

Provide links to relevant policies and legislations

Systems and tools

Names, descriptions
Who use them

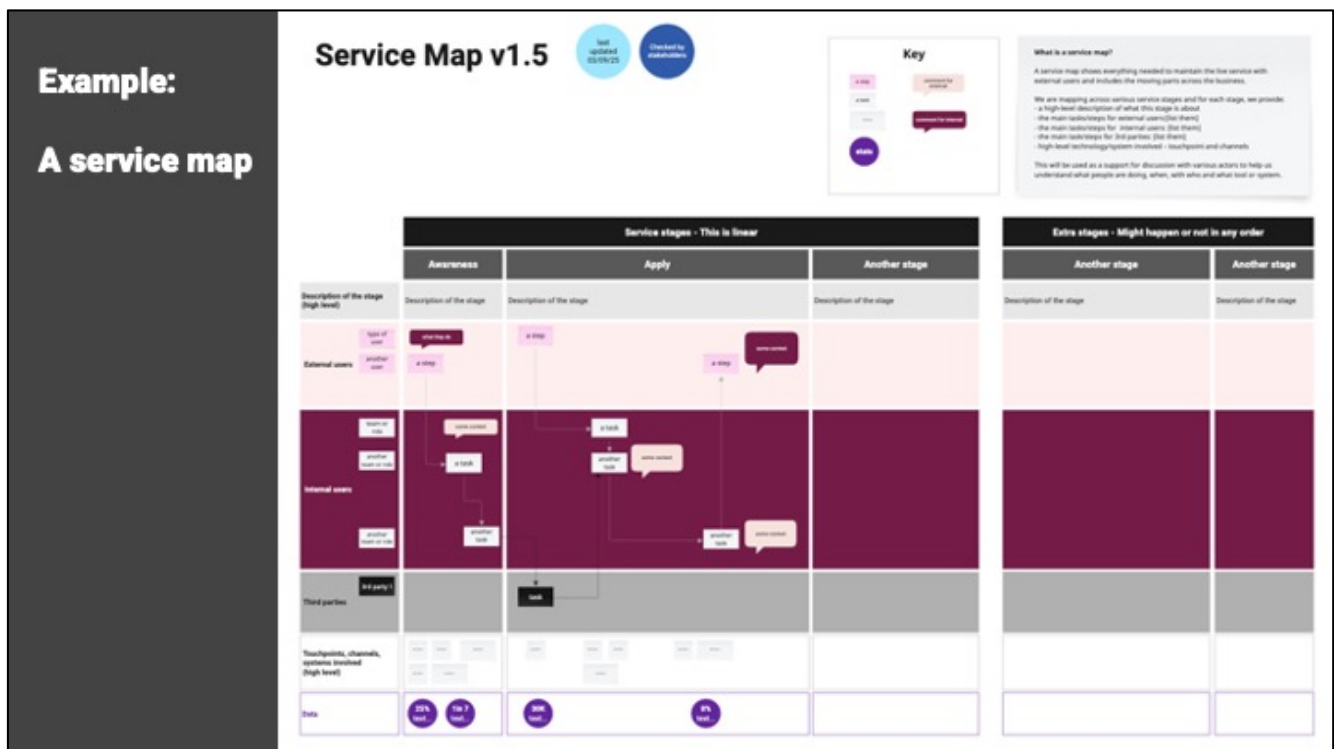
We welcome your feedback

Contact name@dept.gov.uk

Thank you!

I have another part to explain the internal aspects of the delivery of the service, and some areas which were a shape on the visual. I often have one or more slides about the policy and legal aspects, names of the teams and links to related legislation when relevant, and I have a part on the system and tools, where I explain who uses them. Finally I invite for feedback so I can improve when things were missing, incorrect or confusing.

I get more feedback that way, especially from people in operations.



Again, I cannot share an actual map, but I've recreated one. This time it's a service map.

I have a version number, and in the top right corner, I explain what a service map is and what we will use this for, I provide a key for the colours and shapes I'm using and I also add the date when it was last updated, and also say if it's has been checked by stakeholders or not.

The map itself show the usual elements I have in a service map:

The column are each stage of the service, some are linear, here I've put awareness, apply, and another stage - And then more stages which might happen or not in any order.

For the rows, I have a first row that describe each stage at a high level, then a row for the external users and sub rows if there are different types, then one for internal users, again I might have different layers for different type of internal actors. I often have an extra row for third parties delivering the service too

Under this, I have a row for the touchpoints, channels and systems involved at a high level and finally, a row where I add a bit of data when I have it about this specific stage. Across all this, I have boxes explaining tasks, events and arrows connecting them to understand the flow of the steps.

Once the mapping is in a good place, and I want to start sharing wider, I create an alternative format as a slide deck - But this time, I slice the mapping differently.

Example: Turning the service map visual into a deck (1)

Name of the service or project

Service map v1.5

Last updated 03/09/2025

What is a service map

Explanation of the purpose of this type of map

Setting expectations

How to read this map

If people still want to understand and use the visual

Service map v1.5



Description of the map

I still have an 'educational part' to the document and provide a link to a PDF version of the visual as some people might still be interested in seeing it, and then I provide a written description of the visual.

[explain what a service map is]

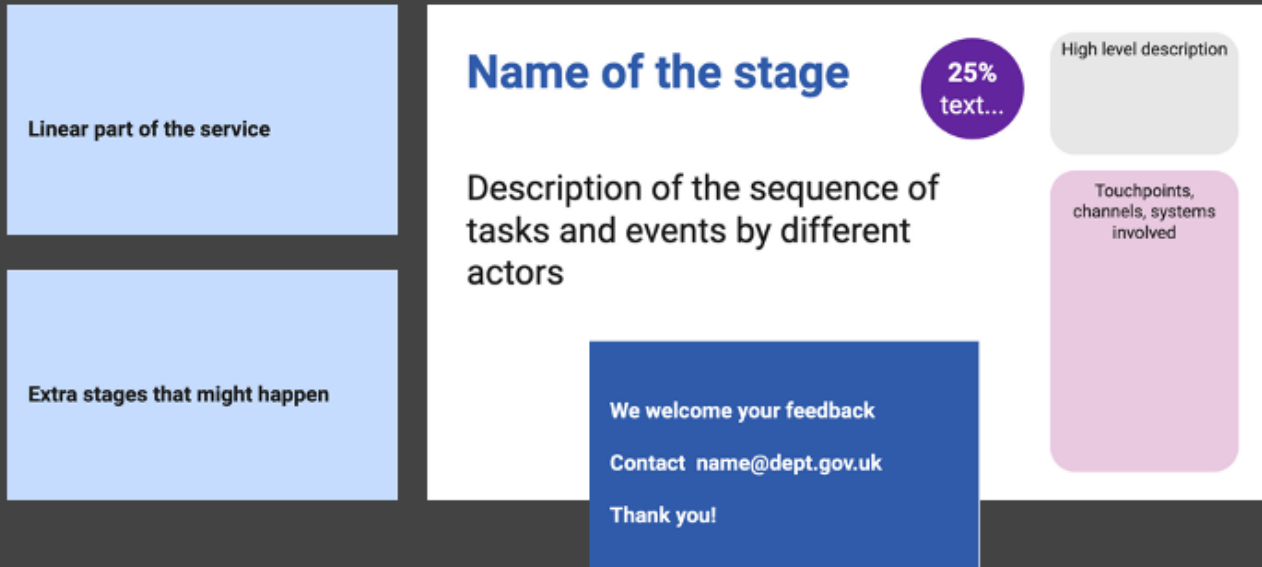
A service map shows everything needed to maintain the live service with external and internal users and includes the moving parts across the service.

We are mapping across various service stages and for each stage, we provide:

- *a high-level description of what this stage is about*
- *the main tasks/steps for external users, internal users and 3rd parties*
- *high-level technology/system involved – touchpoint and channels*

This will be used as a support for discussion with various actors to help us understand what people are doing, when, with who and what tool or system are used

Example: Turning the service map visual into a deck (2)



I start with the linear parts of the service and for each stage, I will provide a description of the sequence of tasks and events by different actors, I'll add any data I might have about this step - For example the percentage of users failing to provide the evidence we need, I have a part of the slide where I give a high level description of the stage, and another to mention the touchpoints, the channels and systems involved.

once I've described all the stages in the linear part of the service, I have a section for extra stages which might happen or not: it could be about making an appeal to a decision or transferring to another service

And finally like for the other map, I always have a slide inviting for feedback and giving a contact to do so.

Pros and cons of alternative formats

- time consuming
- need to maintain two formats

→ this is **accessible** for people who are colour blind, visually impaired and for some neurodivergent types

→ **improve my mapping**

→ **more feedback** and engagement from people who are not designers

not everyone understand visual representations, so text alternative can help.
it improves my mapping as sometimes, while doing the deck I realise that something is not quite right in the visual representation or it makes me realise that actually, there is a relation or a step I do not understand well enough to explain it in a sentence so it needs more work.

Design together



But there are no disabled people in my team

→ many disabilities are not visible

Neurodivergence in tech / creative industry:

→ over 20% - probably up to 50%

→ people sometimes don't declare their disability

You might be thinking, what is she on about? there are no disabled people in my team or among my stakeholders. And maybe you're right.

But the problem is that people often think of disability as something that is visible and permanent. But many disabilities are not visible: like hearing and sight impairments, chronic pain and many more

Do you remember the statistic for neurodiversity? about 1 in 7 people in the general population but in tech and creative industries, it might be up to 50%

This is not visible. You might not know about it, but you surely should think about it. Another thing to keep in mind is that people sometime don't declare their disability to their employer/colleagues for various reasons.

Things can change

- actual employees can become disabled
- a new joiner might be disabled

→ **Make sure your systems, processes and practice are accessible for all**

Creating a safe space

Do not force people to disclose a disability or medical condition

→ offer help for everyone

Instead of providing accommodations for disabled people

→ offer various options to all

Invite for feedback and allow people to reach out privately

So when you are designing with people, it's important to create a safe space. Don't force people to disclose a disability or medical condition. Instead, offer help for everyone.

We talk about 'accommodations' for disabled people, but it's better to offer various options to all instead, so it doesn't sound like you are making a big effort just for them and that way, it will benefit more people who might not have requested anything even though they might need it.

Invite for feedback, and allow people to reach out privately

Don't assume you know what is best

People don't have the same needs even if they have the same condition, and **needs vary in different contexts.**

- always best to ask what would help
- have that discussion with the person
- do not assume you're doing the right thing

Manual of me

- help you tell others what you need
- learn about what other people in your team needs

Do not make people share more than they are willing to!

Examples of sections:

- condition I like to work in
- time and hours I like to work
- best way to communicate with me or provide feedback
- things I'm good at
- things I might need help with
- how I like to be helped

A 'manual of me' can be a great tool to communicate what you need to work well with the rest of your team. I've been doing this in project teams for a while and found that it helps me to tell people what I need and also to understand them better.

In there for example, I will explain that I struggle with numbers, names and acronyms if I do not have a visual support for them and you just say them, because I'm French and my brain does the little gymnastic of translating things so it slows me down, but if I have a visual, I instantly recognise it.

Organising/hosting a session

- before the session: set expectations, provide an agenda, do it again at the start of the actual session
- invite people to tell you if this might not work for them
- if using online tools like Mural or Miro, plan for an alternative
- if over an hour → plan for a break and stick to it
- repeat the question someone asked before answering unless you're sure everyone has heard/seen it

Presenting during a session

- share your slides at the start of a presentation or in your invite
- keep content short and simple, test the accessibility of the deck
- use a mic, speak facing your audience, camera on if online
- leave some space at the bottom of your slides
- describe any image/ diagram, assume at least one person cannot see
- don't assume people can read the text on slides

Getting people in a venue

- access to toilets
- enough space to move around
- can the light be controlled
- sitting arrangement - standing
- provide photos or video of the space, and how to get there
- plan more time!

Earlier, I provided guidance from Scope about physical accessibility at a venue and they have an accessible events toolkit

Key takeaways

Designing for everyone

- think about accessibility right from the start
- do not forget about internal users
- consider neurodivergence and low numeracy in particular
- ask for feedback
- focus on: integration with other services, questions, consistency

accessibility should be addressed right from the start and all along, this includes neurodiversity

make sure anyone can give feedback in a way that suits them, so you can learn how to improve and keep iterating

Design communication

- provide alternative formats for your visuals and maps
- check colour contrast especially for your text
- do not rely on colour alone to convey meaning
- use plain language and explain acronyms
- be careful with numbers
- use accessibility checkers for your slides and word documents
- send your presentation ahead of the meeting

Designing together

- do not assume there are no disabled people in your team
- consider neurodivergence
- do not assume you know what is best
- use manuals of me

Resources



About Accessibility and neurodiversity

- [Past videos \(of the Accessibility Scotland conference\)](#)
- [Inclusive Design 24](#) online and free
- [Public neurodiversity support center](#)
- [The Neurocrats: Civil Service Live podcast](#) on YouTube
- [Estimate how many people using your website might be disabled](#)

Guidances

- [DWP Accessibility manual](#)
- [Accessibility and inclusive design manual](#) from the Department for Education
- Scope: [checking the accessibility of an event or venue](#) and [accessible events toolkit](#)
- [Accessible numbers project](#)
- [Why you need to make your maps accessible](#) - GOV.UK Blog post

Thank you!

To Craig Abbott, Tom Napier, Alice Forward, Lindsay Stephens, Shalom Jesusanmi, Helen Spires, and the whole DWP Service Design Community

And thank you for listening!



Any question?

Get in touch:

stephanie.krus2@engineering.digital.dwp.gov.uk

Or on the cross gov Slack

